Session Two: "Who we are" — made in the image of God

Required Reading: Interior Castle: Study Edition, *the First Dwelling Places,* ch. 1 and 2

Additional Reading: Interpretive notes.

> ***"****Jesus came among us to reveal to us this Trinitarian love and the vocation to participate in a communion of love with the Most Holy Trinity; this is something to which every human person created in God's image and likeness is called. In the light of this mystery, the true identity and dignity of every human being, and specifically of every member of the Church, is revealed. Being spiritual in nature, the human person grows and matures by being in an authentic relationship with God and with others"*
> (OCDS Const. Art. 24a).

Explanatory note: "Teresa begins on a positive note, speaking of the beauty and dignity of the soul. Actually, 'soul' and 'castle' are the same in the symbolic language of the work. And in our language today, the soul refers to the human person. So Teresa begins by speaking of the beauty and dignity of the human person" (Interpretive notes, pg. 42; second edition, pg. 16). We are not merely a spark of God, but God actually *lives* in us and makes us beautiful by His light. Throughout the dwelling places, Teresa raises the question of *who we are*, and our marvelous capacity for God. In every step of the dwelling places, Teresa emphasizes the importance of self-knowledge.

> *"Do you think it matters little for a soul with a wandering mind to understand this truth and see that there is no need to go to heaven in order to speak with one's Eternal Father or find delight in Him? Nor is there any need to shout. However softly we speak, He is near enough to hear us. Neither is there any need for wings to go to find Him. All one need do is go into solitude and look at Him within oneself, and not turn away from so good a Guest but with great humility speak to Him as to a father. Beseech Him as you would a father; tell Him about your trials; ask Him for a remedy against them, realizing that you are not worthy to be His daughter"* (WP, ch. 28.2).

Essential Points to Discuss:

- "It is that we consider our soul to be like a castle made entirely out of a diamond... [We] don't find anything comparable to the magnificent beauty of a soul and its marvelous capacity. …He created us in His own image and likeness" (IC, DP I, 1:1).
- "In explaining that we are made in the image and likeness of God, Teresa points out how we have the capacity for God that transcends the human person" (Interpretive notes, pg. 42; second edition, pg. 16). By raising the question of "who we are," Teresa reminds her readers that God created mankind in His own image and likeness (Gen. 1:26-27).
- Unfortunately, most do not strive for self-knowledge. Rather, most travel through life disconnected from the deeper sense of awareness that can transcend superficial

existence. Some things are good and necessary for everyday life; however, it is too easy to become preoccupied with business affairs and pleasure seeking. The sense of personhood ("who we are") is often bound up in physical appearance, social status or professional standing. As Teresa points out, "[we] limit ourselves to … the outer wall of the castle; that is, with these bodies of ours." Consequently, little effort is made to preserve its beauty (see IC, DP I, 1:2).

- How does one enter the castle from the outer courtyard? "Insofar as I can understand, the door of entry to this castle is prayer and reflection" (IC, DP I, 1:7). "The castle is inhabited by God. To enter it is to enter into relationship with God, who dwells in its inmost dwelling place… To pray is to enter into personal relationship with God" (Interpretive notes, pg. 44; second edition, pg. 17).
- Characteristics of persons who enter the first dwelling places: For even though they are very involved in the world, they have good desires to entrust themselves to God and reflect on who they are, although in a rather hurried fashion. They sometimes pray, but their minds are then filled with business matters. However, they have done quite a bit just by entering the lower rooms of the castle (see IC, DP I, 1:8).
- A central concept of Teresa's spirituality is the realization that God is immanent — that is, He dwells within the innermost mansion of the human soul. For "the Kingdom of God is within you" (Luke 17:21).
- Teresa also reminds her readers that God ("the shining sun") is always in the center of the soul. Nothing can take away the loveliness of His indwelling presence, even as one struggles with sin. "But if a black cloth [one's sin and distractions] is placed over a crystal that is in the sun, obviously the sun's brilliance will have no effect on the crystal even though the sun is shining on it" (IC, DP I, 2:3). Therefore, one's journey into this castle is to re-discover this "shining sun" of God that is already within its center — to come to the realization that all are made in the image and likeness of God.
- "You must not think of these dwelling places in such a way that each one would follow in file after the other; but turn your eyes toward the center, which is the room or royal chamber where the King stays…" (IC, DP I, 2:8).

  Note: Teresa's primary focus is the center as opposed to stages of prayer. This concept is clearly stated in the very beginning: "… in the center and middle is the main dwelling place where the very secret exchanges between God and the soul take place" (IC, DP I, 1:3).
- Teresa stresses the importance of spending time in the room where self-knowledge is dealt with rather than flying off to other rooms. "It is very important for any soul that practices prayer, whether little or much, not to hold itself back and stay in one corner. Let it walk through these dwelling places. … Don't force it to stay a long time in one room alone. **Oh, but if it is in the room of self-knowledge!**" (IC, DP I, 2:8, emphasis added).

<u>Note to formator</u>: Emphasize that self-knowledge is not only about sin, but instead more about knowing one's own personality, one's motives, weaknesses, tendencies, etc. — all that goes into making the person who he is.

- Teresa's understanding of self-knowledge is rooted in pondering the grandeur and majesty of God. "Here it will discover its lowliness better than by thinking of itself…" (IC, DP I, 2:8). "In my opinion **we shall never completely know ourselves if we don't strive to know God**. By gazing at His grandeur, we get in touch with our own lowliness; by looking at His purity, we shall see our own filth; by pondering His humility, we shall see how far we are from being humble" (IC, DP I, 2:9). The advantage of such activity is that the intellect and will, now with God, become nobler and better prepared for every good (see IC, DP I, 2:10). True self-knowledge is rooted in the parallel knowledge of God.

  Note: Humility is intrinsically connected with both knowledge of self and knowledge of God.

- Teresa further observes that in these first dwelling places, persons are still "absorbed in the world and engulfed in their pleasures and vanities, with their honors and pretenses …" (IC, DP I, 2:12). If people are to enter the second dwelling places, it is important that they strive to give up unnecessary pre-occupation with worldly affairs. They should do this in conformity with their state in life (see IC, DP I, 2:14).

- Teresa reminds the reader that the wiles of the devil can cause harm to one's prayer life (see IC, DP I, 2:16-17). Of special interest for Seculars is misplaced "zeal" for noticing others' imperfections while being blind to one's own faults. Also, in Teresa's time people were tempted to do excessive penances; in today's climate, people are more likely to excuse themselves from any penance at all or to do penance with mixed motives.

- "...the local communities of the Secular Order... [are] a place to live and promote personal and communal fellowship with God in Christ and... with other brothers and sisters in accordance with the Teresian charism. … Teresa is aware of the importance of mutual support on the road of prayer and the importance of friendship with others in the common search for God. She also considers as fundamental to such friendship, culture, the human virtues, gentleness, empathy, prudence, discretion, simplicity, kindness, joy, and availability, as we seek to 'walk in truth before God and people'" (OCDS Const. Art. 24 a and b).

- "…true perfection consists in love of God and neighbor; the more perfectly we keep these two commandments the more perfect we will be" (IC, DP I, 2:17).

  "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul and with all your mind. This is the greatest and first commandment. And the second is like it: 'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.' On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets" (Mt. 22:37-40).

"Being in the image of God the human individual possesses the dignity of a person, who is not just something, but someone. This person is capable of self-knowledge, of self-possession and of freely giving himself and entering into communion with other persons…" (CCC 357).